

d) *t(r)engri “sky” (撐犁). The word is not found in Yeniseian: PY *ʔes “god”, “sky” (Starostin 1995: 188). On the other hand, it is present in Altaic: Old Turkic *tängri*, Written Mongolian *tngrī*. It is considered, though, to be a loanword in these languages from a third unknown source (Pelliot 1944).

e) *d(r)ung “milk” (漚). Pulleyblank compared this word with Pumpokol *den* and Arin *teḡul* “milk” < *teḡ* ‘nipple’ + *ul* “water.” It is a reasonably good etymology, although not without some phonetic problems (-u- to -e- and -ŋ to -n, although Pulleyblank is aware of at least the latter one (1962: 252)). Starostin reconstructs PY *de(ʔ)n “nipple”, “milk” > Kott *ten* “nipple”, Arin *teḡul*, Pumpokol *den* “milk” (Starostin 1995: 220).

The evidence above suggests that Pulleyblank’s hypothesis is likely. However the scarcity of the material prevents any definite decisions, because five words are obviously not enough to establish a significant number of regular phonetic correspondences, and all conclusions are based on phonetic similarity. The only regular correspondence that can be detected is that Xiong-nu medial and final /t/ correspond, like Pumpokol /t/ to *s in other Yeniseian languages and in Proto-Yeniseian. This may be classified as a shared innovation, further supported by the fact that Xiong-nu and Pumpokol also share another innovation: fortition of *c- to k-. Unfortunately, there is just one example to support this. Moreover, it looks like that Xiong-nu, similarly to Pumpokol, Ket, and Yug, preserves initial PY *d- while other languages devoice it to t- (cf. PY *de-s “eye” > Ket *de:ś*, Yug *des*, Kott *ti:ś*, Assan *teś*, *tiś*, Arin *ti-eḡ*, Pumpokol *dat* (Starostin 1995: 220). There is, therefore, the possibility that the Xiong-nu language, if it is a Yeniseian language, is most closely related to Pumpokol.

Thus, lexical evidence suggests that the Xiong-nu language is a Yeniseian language, but speaking in mathematical terms this type of evidence is necessary, but not sufficient. For the sufficient evidence we must again look elsewhere. Fortunately, there is a short poem in Jie (< *ket (鞑靼)) language, that is believed to be a variety of Xiong-nu. There are several attempts to explain this poem on the basis of Turkic (Ramstedt 1922), (Bazin 1948), (Gabain 1949). I agree with Pulleyblank that none of them can be considered successful (Pulleyblank 1962: 264), but for the sake of clarity I will discuss Ramstedt and Bazin’s attempts as examples below.

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